



OKLAHOMA
Rehabilitation Services



COLORADO
Division of Vocational
Rehabilitation
Department of Labor and Employment



ThinkCollege
INSTITUTE FOR COMMUNITY INCLUSION, UMASS BOSTON

Building College Pathways to Employment: Collaboration between Vocational Rehabilitation Agencies and Inclusive Postsecondary Education Programs

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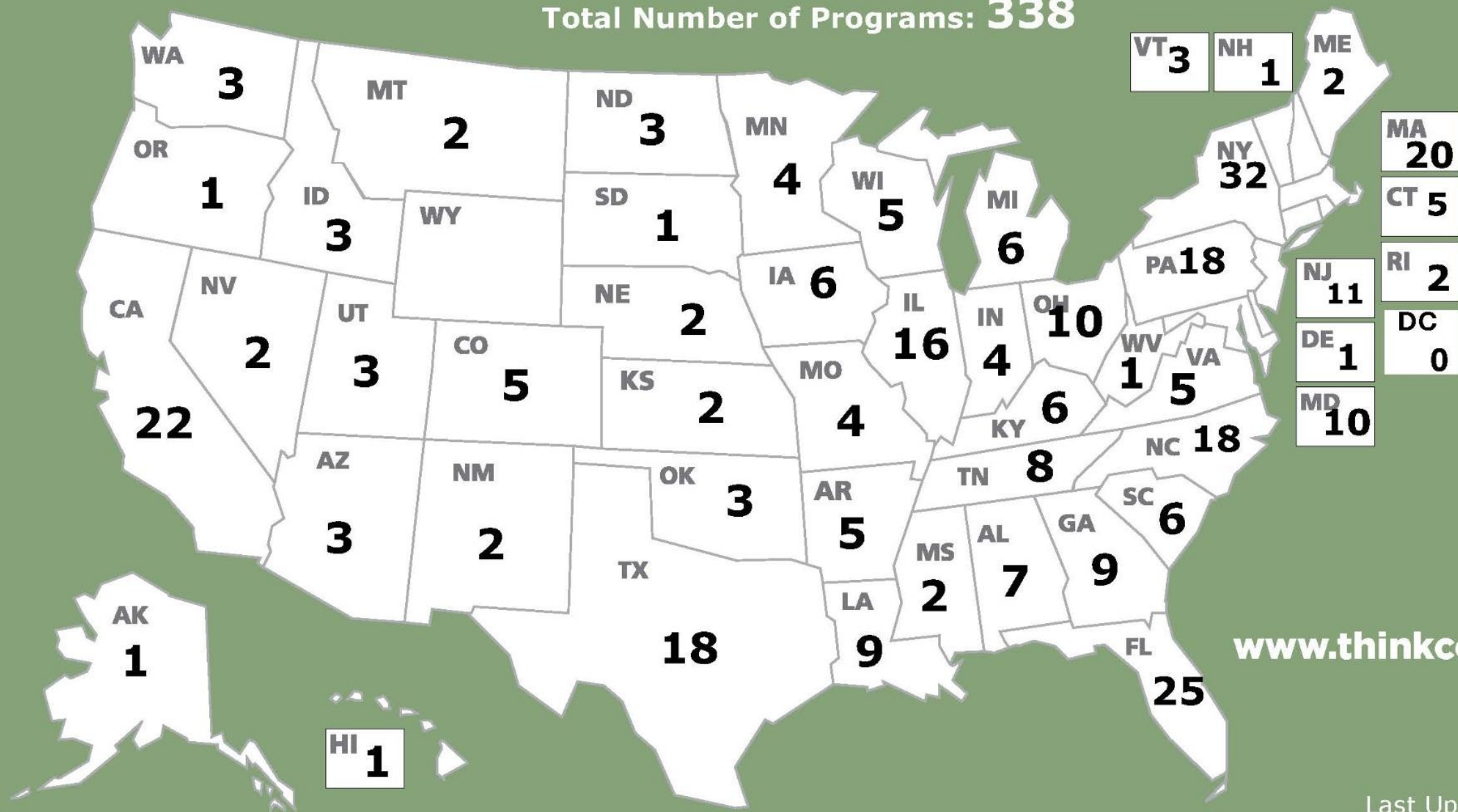
What is Think College?

Think College is a national technical assistance, research, training, and evaluation center dedicated to developing, expanding and improving higher education options for students with intellectual disability.

www.thinkcollege.net

College Options for Students with Intellectual Disability, August 2024

Total Number of Programs: **338**



Think College

www.thinkcollege.net

Last Updated: 7/31/24

Growing funding and knowledge

- \$165+ million in federal funding
- State funding in 16 states
- Data on 4,800+ students
- Growing research base
- Newly developed accreditation options and training



Some Key Features of Inclusive College Programs

- Student-centered approach
- Alternate admissions process/requirements
- Emphasis on WBL and paid employment
- Access to credit/audit classes
- Program specific non-degree credentials
- Housing opportunities based on campus
- Some financial aid availability



Transition Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability (TPSID)

Government grant funded model demonstration projects

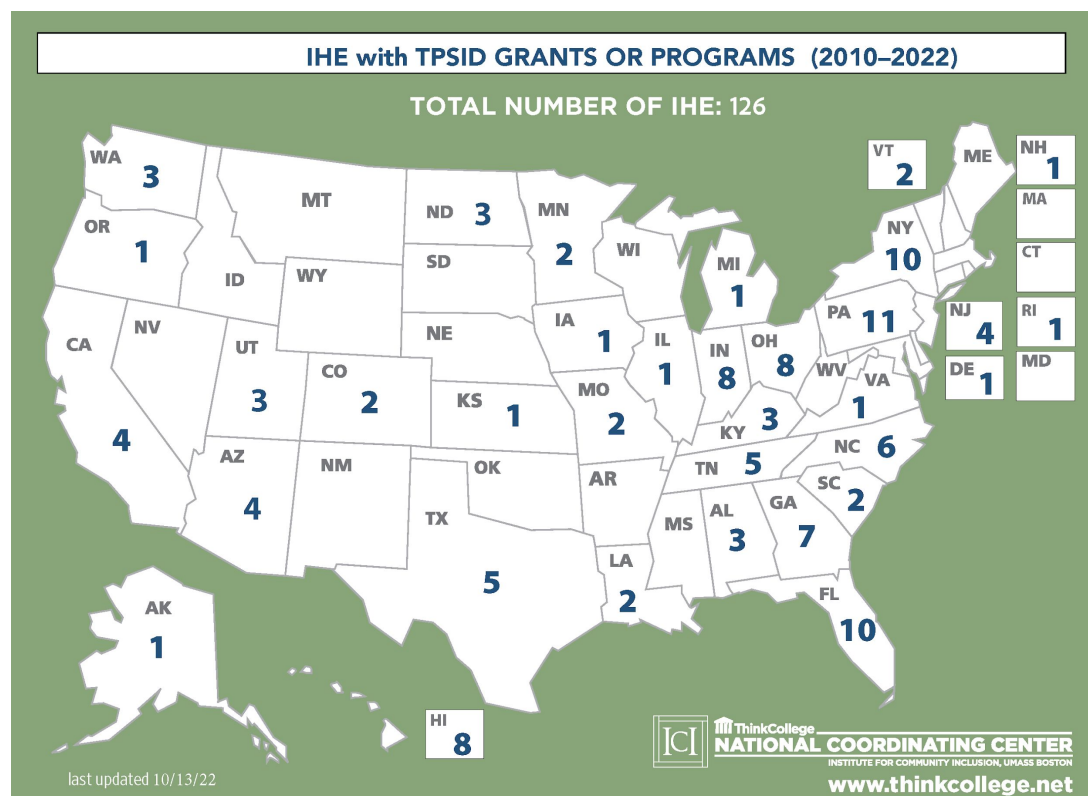
TPSIDs create, expand, or enhance high-quality, inclusive higher education experiences to support positive outcomes for individuals with ID.

Collect and share data with Think College National Coordinating Center



ThinkCollege
NATIONAL COORDINATING CENTER
INSTITUTE FOR COMMUNITY INCLUSION, UMASS BOSTON

TPSID Model Demonstration Grantees



Since 2010, TPSID grants have supported **126 colleges and universities** to advance higher education for students with ID

Approximately **1/3 of the higher education programs** enrolling students with ID have received TPSID funding at some time.

12 Years of TPSIDs (2010 – 2022)

Paid jobs while in program

3,675



Course enrollments

59,727



Inclusive course enrollments

26,597



Students who completed program and
earned credential

2,134



Paid Employment After Exit

1 Year After Exit

59%

had a paid job

402 respondents

2 Years After Exit

66%

had a paid job

196 respondents

3 Years After Exit

67%

had a paid job

102 respondents

TPSID Data: Predictor of Employment

- Specialized courses are a negative predictor of employment
- Students who obtained a paid job while enrolled were almost **15 times more** likely to have a paid job at exit than those who did not
- Earning a credential awarded by the IHE almost **doubled the odds** of having a paid job at exit

Research on impact of PSE on employment for people with ID using RSA-911 data

IPSE is cost effective



Cimera et al., 2018



Findings: PSE for people with ID is both cost-effective (cheaper than other services) and cost-efficient (pays for itself over time).

PSE Impact on Employment and Earnings



VR clients with ID who experienced PSE were more than twice as likely to be employed and had increased earnings compared to their counterparts who had not had access to PSE while receiving VR services
-Sannicandro et al 2018



Youth who received PSE services as part of their IPE were 14% more likely to exit with paid integrated employment and earned 51% higher wages than those who did not access PSE services
Smith et al., 2018



VR clients who completed a postsecondary certificate or degree earned more than those who did not
-Miller et al., 2019



For transition aged youth with ASD the odds of exiting VR with an employment outcome were 1.59 times higher with PSE services
Rast et al., 2019



What is happening in Oklahoma?





- 7 Divisions
- Over 1,000 employees
- 25 Statewide Programs
- School for the Blind
- School for the Deaf



OKLAHOMA
Rehabilitation
Services

Beginnings...

PROCESS:



Early Discussions – Early Relationships/Education re: IPSE
Information/Discussion with other states: Ex: Pennsylvania
Team Discussion – Key leaders for a working session
Budget and Logistics – Discovery Period
Pilot Development – Develop Pilot Contract with First Program

Why?:

Data backs up improved employment rates for graduates
DRS Mission alignment with successful employment outcomes

DRS and IPSE Programs Now

IPSE Contracts in place:

- 3 CTP designated programs
- 1 degree-seeking program for students with autism

Up to \$3,000 per semester

- Must be VR Client
- Based on Family Financial Guidelines
- All paperwork must be completed before approval
- Counselors must be educated and involved prior to student's acceptance into IPSE program
- IPSE must be included in IPE

Internships

- Up to 15 hours per week
- Minimum Wage
- 10 weeks per semester
- DRS pays IHE/Program; Program pays student
- Counselors check on student's progress and employment in area of interest

Partnerships and More

Workforce Boards – “IPSE NEXT”; Partnership with Pre-ETS

Pilot project with 2 Work Skills Trainers hired to assist IPSE students with community employment both during and after the IPSE program.

Trainers assist with all things employment.

Potential Pilot Projects –

Career Tech and Community College

Potential to utilize Pre-ETS Specialist as point person.

Discussions ongoing

Legislation – for students attending CTP-designated programs

Oklahoma Access & Achievement Scholarship-

Pays equivalent of full tuition for up to 5 years from first enrolled semester

Oklahoma Tuition Aid Grant – IPSE students now eligible with language change

Considerations



State Directors

- Start with a Pilot
- Data backs up the “why”
- If you lead, others will join!

Counselors/ Program Mgrs

- **Long Game = Improved Employment!**
- Reinforce Leadership Support
- Issues will happen, solve them!

Educate and Inform

- Identify gaps in educating staff
- Provide information in a variety of formats: video, infographics, email

Work in Progress; Issues are a chance to Improve!

What is happening in Colorado?



Rachel Hoard

- Supported Employment Program Manager



Where We Started

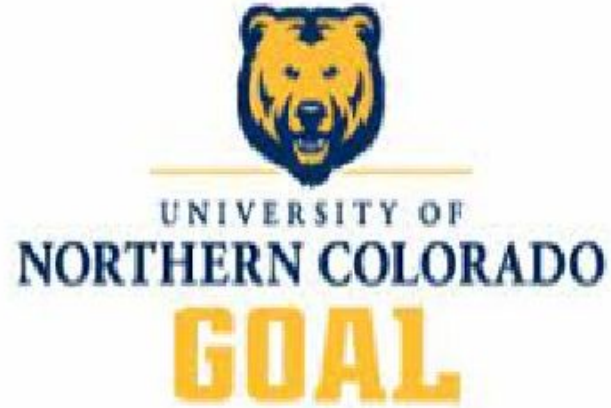
- 2008
 - Federal Reauthorization of Higher Education Opportunity Act passed nationally
- 2016
 - CO was 1 of 3 states that had not offered inclusive higher education
 - CO SB-0196 Inclusive Higher Education Act passed
 - Established 3 pilot programs at institutes across the state
- 2020
 - Added Inclusive Higher Education Skills Training Fee to DVR Fee Schedule
- 2022
 - HB 1107 Inclusive Higher Education Opportunities Act passes

DVR Supporting IHE

1. Tuition to the university (if FNA allows)
 - a. Program Fee is the responsibility of the family. Per DVR fee schedule **we do not pay the program fee** that is listed within the tuition items on the tuition statement.
2. IHE Fee payment directed to the IHE program
 - a. Usual and customary rate, **not to exceed \$3000.00 per semester**



Approved IHE programs



Upcoming IHE programs

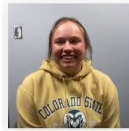


Prevention Research Center
College of Agricultural Sciences
Center for Community Partnerships



Congratulations class of 2024

In May of 2024, 19 students graduated from Inclusive Higher Education programs all across Colorado! Colorado now has a total of 63 students with intellectual disabilities who have completed college in Colorado! Click on the picture below to access the IN! graduation page and learn more about each graduate.



Caley, ACC



Gabby, ACC



Tristan, ACC



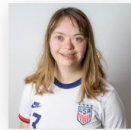
Grace, Regis



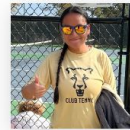
Jen, Regis



Kristina,
Regis



Sophia, Regis



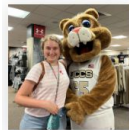
Emerald,
UCCS



Grace, UCCS



Katelyn,
UCCS



Makena,
UCCS



Avery, UNC



Jason, UNC



HB 1107 Inclusive Higher Education Opportunities Act

- \$450,000/year
- 5 year grant
- Allowing colleges across the state to apply for needed funding to establish or expand Inclusive Higher Education pathways for students with Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities
- Established evaluation requirements on student and program outcome data for grant recipients that is reported to IN! As well as the Colorado Dept. of Higher Education
- \$267,000 left of grant to establish IHE on the Western Slope

UCCS IS Accredited!!!

The University of Colorado at Colorado Springs (UCCS) is now only the 2nd inclusive postsecondary program in the country to receive National Program Accreditation from the Inclusive Higher Education Accreditation Council (IHEAC)



Resources for working with VR

Code of Federal Regulations for VR, Comments Section

34 CFR 361.48(b): Services for individuals who have applied or been determined eligible for VR services (*Advanced Training*)

“Of these commenters, a few suggested that §361.48(b)(6) allow DSUs to provide tuition and other services for students with intellectual or developmental disabilities in a Comprehensive Transition and Postsecondary Program.”

Resources for working with VR

Code of Federal Regulations for VR, Comments Section Continued...

34 CFR 361.48(b): Services for individuals who have applied or been determined eligible for VR services (*Advanced Training*)

“Similarly, we clarify here that the vocational and other training services specified in final§361.48(b)(6) encompass tuition and other services for students with intellectual or developmental disabilities in a Comprehensive Transition and Postsecondary Program for Students with Intellectual Disabilities.”

Resources for working with VR

Transition Guide to Postsecondary Education & Employment for Students and Youth w/ Disabilities (RSA, 2020)

<https://sites.ed.gov/idea/files/postsecondary-transition-guide-august-2020.pdf>: **Vocational Rehabilitation Supports for Postsecondary Education**

“The VR program assists individuals with disabilities, including students and youth with disabilities, to acquire the knowledge and skills needed to achieve employment that can sustain economic independence.”

Resources for working with VR

Transition Guide to Postsecondary Education & Employment for Students and Youth w/ Disabilities (RSA, 2020) Continued. . .

<https://sites.ed.gov/idea/files/postsecondary-transition-guide-august-2020.pdf>: **Vocational Rehabilitation Supports for Postsecondary Education**

“If it is determined to be necessary. . . VR agencies can provide financial support to eligible individuals to pay for or offset higher education-related expenses, including college expenses not covered by student financial aid, or disability related expenses.”

Resources for working with VR

Increasing Postsecondary opportunities & success for students and youth with Disabilities (OSERs and OPSE, 2019)

<https://thinkcollege.net/sites/default/files/files/resources/increasing-post-secondary-opportunities-and-success-09-17-2019.pdf>: **Can VR funds be used to support a student with a disability in a CTP?**

“Yes. VR funds can be used to support students with disabilities in CTPs if certain conditions are met. Students, youth, and their families, with the assistance of the VR program as appropriate, should consider the wide array of postsecondary options that are available, including but not limited to, two- and four-year colleges and universities, career and technical schools, adult education programs, . . .

Resources for working with VR

Increasing Postsecondary opportunities & success for students and youth with Disabilities (OSERs and OPSE, 2019)

<https://thinkcollege.net/sites/default/files/files/resources/increasing-postsecondary-opportunities-and-success-09-17-2019.pdf>: **Can VR funds be used to support a student with a disability in a CTP?**

“ . . . and comprehensive transition and postsecondary education programs. A comprehensive transition program is an example of one postsecondary option for which the VR program could provide assistance to students and youth with intellectual disabilities when appropriate and agreed to on their approved IPE.”

Resources for working with VR

Think College

Think College Home Page

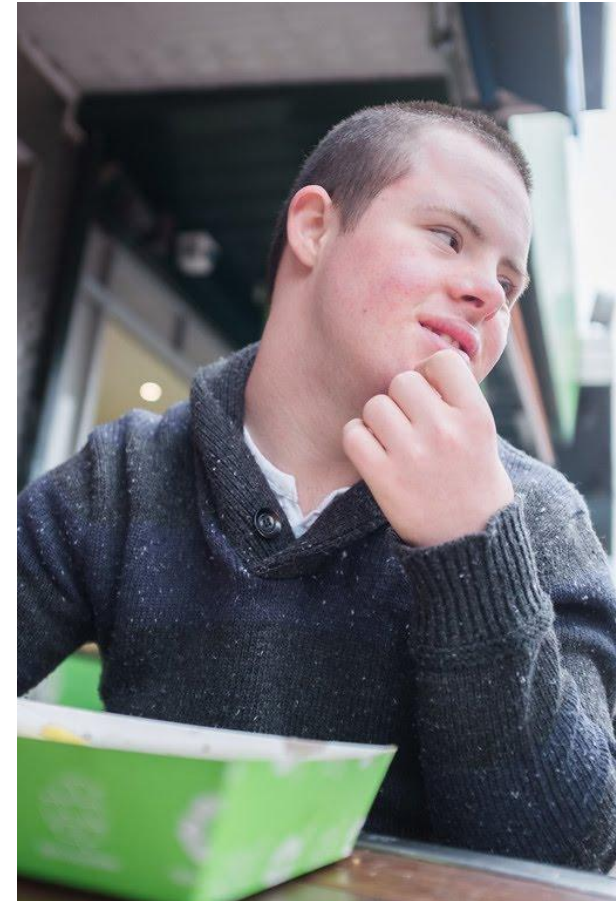
- <https://thinkcollege.net/>

Think College Resource Library (VR Specific)

- https://thinkcollege.net/resource-search?sort=field_resource_publication_date&order=desc

Let's discuss...outcomes

How has the collaboration between VR and IPSE programs improve student employment outcomes?



Let's discuss...collaboration

Share some strategies for fostering collaboration between VR agencies and IPSE programs to enhance employment for students with intellectual disability



Let's discuss...barriers

What are common barriers to collaboration between VR and higher education programs for students with ID, and how might we address those challenges?



Final Comments



If you could provide one final piece of advice to VR personnel related to employment, IPSE, VR, what would it be?

Free VR Resources Hyperdoc!

Scan me:-)

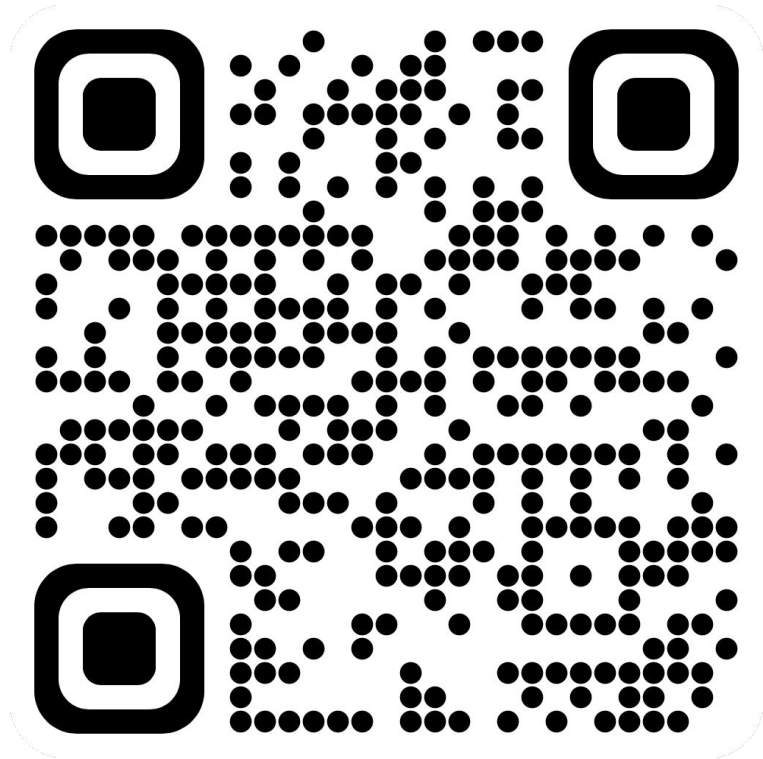
**Scan this QR code to access
the full list of resources!**



Or visit this URL:

tcollege.me/VRhyperdoc

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